



Examination Report

Literature in English

6875

EGCSE

2025

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Paper 6875/01

General comments

The number of candidates that sat for this paper was slightly higher compared to the previous year – 2024. There was a tremendous improvement in the performance when compared to the previous year. This could be attributed to the remarkable performance of a number of schools that do not have a previous record of excelling in Literature in English Paper 1.

The level of difficulty of the paper was almost the same as of last year, however, questions 9, 13, 23 and 27 were popular and favoured by most candidates. In drama, candidates generally struggled with the passage-based questions, 2, 4 and 7. Most candidates who chose question 4 and 7 were unable to adequately respond to the question as they would focus on one aspect, completely ignoring the other. The examiners observed, for instance, that most candidates were giving excellent character sketches of Asagai and Beneatha, completely ignoring the part on their relationship. This was also the case in *Twelfth Night* as candidates would simply identify Malvolio's personality and leave out the part on his attitude.

The candidates' main weakness in the poetry question was in that candidates were not able to relate how the title of the poem, *Break, Break, Break* and part of the opening lines of the first stanza convey the pain of loss and separation. The most challenging questions were all the passage-based questions in **Section C, Prose**. The challenge facing most candidates is how to write the topic sentence and make it speak to the question without directly using the evidence from the passage, especially where the feelings have been given i.e. 'fear and anxiety'. This year the number of rubric infringement incidents was significantly low but there was an increase in the number of candidates who wrote excessively on two sections and as a result ran out of time to adequately attempt the last question. There are still centres though that still struggle with incidents of rubric infringement. These are reminded that a candidate should at least cover a question on Drama, Poetry and Prose. Most importantly, candidates should attempt at least one passage-based question.

Comments on Specific Questions

SECTION A: DRAMA

J.B PRIESTLY: *An Inspector Calls*

Question *1

The task required candidates to state how they perceived Eric's personality in the passage. This was a popular question with candidates and was fairly well done. Most candidates were able to identify Eric's personality and support it with relevant detail from the passage. These were able to explain the quote and conclude with a personal feeling that correlates to the topic sentence. However, weak responses misconstrued the word

impressions for feelings. Such candidates simply wrote about how they feel about Eric without referring to his personality.

Question 2

This question required candidates to debate the extent to which they agreed with the view that Priestley's play shows a world in which members of the older generation do not take responsibility for their actions. However, this was challenging as most candidates simply wrote on one side of the question which is, members of the older generation do not take responsibility for their actions. Only a few candidates were able to tackle the other side of the question which shows that even amongst the younger generation there is a character in the text who fails to take responsibility for his actions. This is none other than Gerald who, just like the Birlings, does not accept that he is culpable for the death of Eva Smith.

Question 3

This question required that the candidates write their thoughts as Birling just after the Inspector had left his house. The moment proved problematic for many candidates as they were not sure of the exact moment from which their thoughts should begin. Most candidates assumed that at this moment Birling was convinced that the inspector was fake and therefore wanted to call his police acquaintance to verify the presence of an 'Inspector Goole'. Other responses portrayed Birling as very remorseful yet in the text Birling is adamant that he played no part in Eva's death. There were, however, those who were able to assume Birling's voice and unwavering stance that he played no role in the death of the girl. These were able to capture Birling's dislike for the Inspector and his commitment to protect his good name at all costs.

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE: *Twelfth Night*

Question *4. The question required candidates to state what the passage reveals about the personality of Malvolio and his attitude towards other people. This was generally not a popular question just like all questions falling under *Twelfth Night*. The few responses to this one simply pointed out what Malvolio was doing in the extract without using the correct words to describe his personality and his attitude towards other people.

Question 5

This was not a popular question to warrant a response.

Question 6

This was not a popular question to warrant a response.

LORRAINE HANSBERRY: *A Raisin in the Sun*

Question *7

This was a popular question which required candidates to state what the passage reveals about the personalities of Asagai and Beneatha and the way they relate to each other. Most candidates wrote on the characters of Asagai and Beneatha forgetting that there is the other part which they had to write about: their relationship. Others would first analyse the personalities and then later deal with the relationship. This weakened their responses as they were expected to deal with the personality and the relationship concurrently. However, there were candidates who dealt with both aspects of the question fairly well. These were able to bring out Asagai and Beneatha's personalities and their relationship clearly. A few misunderstood Asagai's playful banter with Beneatha with regards to her 'mutilated hair'.

Question 8

A reasonable number of candidates opted for this question. The question required candidates to show the ways in which the importance of family and morality to mama are made so dramatically vivid in the text. Candidates were able to draw from the text relevant incidents that show that family and morality are important to mama. These were able to deal specifically with importance of family and then morality without tying the two together. However, there were candidates that simply highlighted what mama does in the text without explaining how it relates to the two themes raised by the question.

Question 9

This was a popular question among candidates and a vast number of them performed admirably well in it. The question required candidates to write thoughts as Ruth after she had just heard that Walter has given away all the money for the business. Most candidates were able to identify the moment and thus had the correct thoughts and feelings to begin their responses. These were able to capture Ruth's voice, which at this moment is full of disappointment and despair. However, there were candidates who tended to be sympathetic towards Walter and had harsh words for Mama. These scored low scores. Other candidates wrote as if they were having a conversation with Walter thus their thoughts were largely inappropriate.

SECTION B: POETRY

JACK HYDES (ed): *Touched with Fire*

Question *10

This question was not popular with candidates. It required candidates to state how the words of the poet vividly portray the impact of suffering on humankind. This was one of the most challenging questions for candidates as they failed to explain how the poet has shown the effect of suffering on humankind. Candidates would

simply paraphrase the lines of the poem or quote without explaining how those portions portray the impact of suffering on humankind.

Question 11

The responses were too few to warrant a general comment.

Question 12

This question was not popular with many candidates. However, there were a few candidates who chose it and most of the responses were good. Candidates were able to recall the lines of the poem especially the poem, *Little Boy Crying*. On the other hand, there were some candidates who confused it with the poem *The Toys*.

BRIAN WALTER and FELICITY WOOD (eds.): *Groundwork: An Introduction to Reading and Writing about Poetry*

Question *13

This was a popular question. Unfortunately, it was dismally done by a majority. It required candidates to explore how the poet has vividly conveyed the pain of loss and separation. Almost all of the candidates struggled to grasp the relevance of the title, *Break, Break, Break* and the opening lines of the poem to the question. Candidates would simply give a flawed analysis of the poem in their opening paragraphs and only succeeded in addressing the question from stanza 2 onwards. There were, however, centres that performed admirably well in this question as they were able to note that the title symbolically conveys the pain of loss by showing how life that promises so much, ends prematurely. These were able to sustain their explanation of how the words of the poet convey the pain of loss and separation.

Question 14

This question was obviously not as popular as question 13 but still quite a sizeable number of candidates chose it, especially the poem, *The Blues is You in Me*. It required candidates to discuss how the poet's presentation of the situation in the poem affected them. Most of those who attempted it could not recall the poem but tended to write about the history of South Africa during the apartheid era without referring to the poem. The same tendency to relate the poem to South Africa's racial past was noted in the poem, *First Day After the War*.

Question 15

This was another question which was not popular with many centres. It required candidates to explore how the poets in either *Song* or *African Grass* teach powerful life lessons. Candidates had to demonstrate their knowledge of the text in answering the question and explain the powerful life lessons conveyed by the poem. Most candidates were simply narrating the poem without answering the question and this resulted in poor

scores. Those that made an attempt to respond to the questions simply gave trivial lessons e.g. the poet teaches a lesson that a lot of grass grows in Africa.

ELISE VARGA (ed.): *Unbroken Chains: An Anthology of Poetry*

Question *16

This was not a popular question among candidates. The question required candidates to explore how the poet uses powerful language to describe a painful situation. Candidates struggled to show how the writer's choice of words in the poem describes a painful situation.

Question 17

General comment cannot be made as question was not chosen.

Question 18

This was not a popular question among candidates. However, the few that selected it were able to recall the lines of the poems as these are generally interesting poems. The candidates were able to bring out the relevant emotions the poems evoke in them. Weak responses would base their writings on one or two lines from the entire poem and keep repeating them in their paragraphs.

SECTION C: PROSE

HARPER LEE: *To Kill a Mockingbird*

Question *19

The number of centres studying this text is on the rise but unfortunately candidates did not do that well in this question. The question required candidates to explain how Lee has created feelings of outrage and tension for them. Candidates were unable to link the key words of the question, 'outrage' and 'tension' to the relevant incidents in the passage. A glaring shortcoming in most candidates lies in the inability to craft a topic sentence based on their interpretation of the incident in the text in relation to the question. Most candidates used what should be the evidence to formulate their main sentence. This forced markers to find the implied main idea in the explanation thus adversely affecting the candidates' final score.

Question 20

This was a popular question with many candidates who study this text. It required candidates to explain how Lee makes them feel about Jem and Scout's relationship. Candidates were able to recall the kind of relationship Scout and Jem have and succeeded in attaching the appropriate feelings. However, there were instances where candidates simply described the relationship between Scout and Jem without expressing their own feelings.

Question 21

This question was also popular amongst candidates. It required candidates to write Mayella's thoughts after the jury had passed a guilty verdict on Tom Robinson. This question was not well done mainly because candidates failed to capture Mayella's thoughts and feelings in this particular moment. Most assumed that Mayella was guilt-ridden after the verdict had been passed and thus came up with largely inappropriate thoughts. Only a few candidates noted the relief Mayella felt once the verdict was given and that she momentarily regretted framing an innocent man in Tom.

CHINUA ACHEBE: *Things Fall Apart*

Question *22

This was quite a popular question with most candidates but was mainly poorly done. It required the candidates to explain how Achebe's writing in the passage creates feelings of fear and anxiety for the candidate and/or the characters involved. The biggest hindrance for most candidates was the inability to state how the passage creates fear and anxiety. Candidates were expected for instance to write, 'The men's hostile and aggressive behavior towards Ikemefuna creates fear and anxiety in the passage'. From there candidates would have to concisely cite the evidence in the passage then explain it and lastly attach a personal feeling.

Question 23

This was another popular question among candidates. The question required candidates to say what they thought makes Obierika such a memorable character. The question, though quite accessible, proved difficult for some candidates. These confused Obierika with another character in the text Ogbuefi Ezeugo and thus credited the personality traits of this character to Obierika. However, there were candidates who were able to state what in their opinion makes Obierika's character unforgettable in the text. These were aware that Obierika's is Okonkwo's alter-ego and pointed out the traits that prove that. They also clearly mentioned Obierika's characteristics that make him a memorable character.

Question 24

This was also a popular question but was not well done, generally. Candidates were supposed to write thoughts as Ekwefi after Okonkwo had nearly shot her. One of the glaring challenges in the candidates' answers was that the knowledge of who Ekwefi is was lacking. This was coupled with the fact that candidates appeared oblivious of the circumstances leading to the shot being fired. These challenges therefore made it impossible for candidates to come up with relevant thoughts and feelings. Most would write that Ekwefi would think of avenging herself to Okonkwo and also what would have happened to her children had Okonkwo shot her. Only a few candidates performed well on this one and demonstrated good knowledge of the character of Ekwefi.

BARRIE WADE (ed.): *Into the Wind: Contemporary Stories in English*

Question *25

This was another question which was popular among candidates, however, just like question 19 and 22 was poorly done. This question required candidates to explain the ways in which they think Lessing's writing creates tension and made them feel pity for Tom. Candidates struggled to come up with a good opening sentence depicting the way the author creates tension and made them feel pity for Tom. Most candidates would have the evidence in the topic sentence. They would then proceed to explain the evidence followed by the repetition of the word 'pity', yet this is a stated feeling in the question. Other candidates completely misunderstood the passage and treated it as an unseen text viewing Tom as a young innocent boy who has accidentally stumbled upon a naked woman. There were though, good responses that highlighted the tension and pity for Tom in the woman's unwelcoming attitude towards him and his consequent struggle to express himself in front of the woman, making him look stupid.

Question 26

This question was relatively unpopular. It required candidates to explain how they think Ekwensi's portrayal of the Stranger in the text makes him an interesting and pitiable character. Candidates' responses tended to fail to show how the stranger from Lagos has been presented as a very interesting and pitiful character. This was largely due to the fact that most of what the stranger does in the text and how he is presented escaped the attention of the candidates. However, there were candidates who were able to recall that the stranger looked mysterious to the people thus drawing their attention. Some pitied the Stranger for being attracted to a woman who was already someone's fiancée.

Question 27

This was another popular question and was generally well done by most candidates. It required candidates to write their thoughts as the hitchhiker having just stolen the book of tickets in which the policeman had written details about the driver's traffic offence and the black book which had the hitchhiker's personal details. Good responses were able to come up with relevant feelings and thoughts of the hitchhiker at this moment. These were able to note that he is happy and proud of his trade as a finger smith. However, weaker responses would show the hitchhiker as someone who was regretful of his actions and even feeling angry towards the driver for speeding the vehicle leading to their encounter with the police officer. Such responses were deeply flawed and fetched low marks.

Recommendations

- Educators must emphasise the importance of adhering to the instructions on the cover of both the question paper and the answer booklet. It is vitally important for candidates to write their centre numbers, candidate numbers and names on the answer booklets.
- To address prevalent rubric infringement, teachers are encouraged to give full Literature in English papers (make use of mock paper) to candidates and then ascertain if candidates do conform to the instructions in their selection of questions.
- Educators must also emphasise the importance of giving the essays equal attention as they all carry equal marks. This will also help eliminate the growing trend of candidates answering only two questions supposedly because they ran out of time.
- Candidates must be made aware that passage-based questions are not to be treated as an unseen text. Knowledge of what has happened leading up to the selected passage is key to answering a passage-based question.
- Educators must teach candidates how to construct the main sentence of the paragraph. They must dissuade candidates from reproducing lines of the passage as their point. For example, candidates write, 'The passage creates fear and anxiety because the men were carrying sheathed matchets over their left shoulders'. This is incorrect as evidence has been used as a topic sentence. Candidates ought to write thus: 'The men carrying dangerous weapons while in the company of Ikemefuna creates fear and anxiety. Then this will be followed by the evidence from the text, sheathed matchets over their left shoulders'. The learner must then explain the evidence and then conclude with a personal feeling.
- Teachers need to impress on the minds of the candidates that the strength of an extract question lies in citing relevant evidence from the passage to substantiate the argument raised. Paraphrasing and generalising must be discouraged.
- When responding to traditional essay questions candidates tend to use the extract question. This disadvantages candidates as they find themselves with very little or no material to craft their responses. Candidates are allowed to use information from extract to answer traditional essay questions if the passage relates to the question, but such occurrences are not guaranteed to happen. For them to present good responses to traditional essay questions, they must consider the entire text.
- In the traditional essay questions citing accurately from the text is not demanded but candidates must demonstrate their knowledge of the text by echoing the text in their response.
- With empathy questions teachers must highlight the importance of the moment on which the thoughts are based and of knowing that particular character very well. Thoughts in actual fact deal with

characterisation and without an excellent comprehension of the characters and the moments they go through in the text it becomes impossible to craft relevant thoughts and feelings.

- Teachers are encouraged to attend Literature in English workshops as they help shed light on some of the recommendations raised here.

Paper 6875/02

General Comments

This year saw an improvement in the number of candidates who sat for Literature in English Paper 2 compared to last year.

Candidate's performance was fairly well done as most were able to score in the upper bands. As usual, the paper offered candidates with two options to choose from where they either choose a passage or a poem. Question 1 proved particularly popular than Question 2. This is because it was quite common to find a whole centre to have answered only question 1 and only one or two candidates would attempt question 2 in other centres. Question 1 required candidates to express their feelings based on what was happening in the passage, while Question 2 required candidates to bring out how the poem is vivid and memorable as they read it. As noted, most candidates leaned more towards the passage over the poem, yet in the previous year it had been noted that both were answered equally. Most candidates were able to relate to the first question more than the poem. Candidates found it easier to state how they felt even though some would deviate from the question by stating their life experiences. With the poem, candidates had a problem mostly with understanding the language used by the poet and were thus unable to bring out how it was vivid and memorable. What was expected of candidates was to understand the language of both the passage and the poem, which then automatically helped in understanding and answering the questions. Their feelings in the first question were supposed to heighten with the passage, not just a repetition of feelings from the beginning to the end. With the second question, candidates were expected to find the deeper meaning of the poet's language in order to see how vivid and memorable it was with imagery employed by the poet. What was also noted was that candidates were treating the bullet points as the question instead of as a guide to answering the main question.

Comments on Specific Questions

Question 1

This was a popular question. It required candidates to express their own feelings based on what was happening in the passage. The question was generally well done by candidates. Candidates that did well were those that were able to engage with the passage throughout. They showed understanding of the implied meanings and the language used by the writer, for example, "drunk as a fiddler", and "he roared". They were able to unpack what it meant and how it contributed to how they felt as they read the passage, more especially about the character, Khalima Zungu. Candidates' feelings also varied with the incidents in the passage. Their feelings were not flat but heightened as the passage reached its climax, where Khalima burns his own house

with him inside. Their feelings would also vary from being negative to positive depending on what was happening at that time.

Candidates who did well also understood the passage as a whole. They saw that Khalima was a troublesome man who drank a lot and would come home late to abuse his family while they slept. Instead of feeling pity for him, they saw that he got what he deserved when his wife left him. They sympathised with the wife and supported her decision to leave. They even interpreted the similes and metaphors employed by the writer like, “taking out the yolk and white of the egg” with reference to Zungu’s wife taking all the furniture, leaving the house empty like a “shell”. They commented on Zungu’s former job in the Railway Police Force, in relation to his drunkenness, and they supposed that he might have been fired due to his habit of drinking. They even condemned his act of making rash decisions which then came back to haunt him as he had no house, no food and no family, yet he had thought at the time he was revenging by burning down his house.

Weaker responses were characterised by candidates failing to state their feelings clearly due to vocabulary constraints. They would even come up with their own versions of feelings like, ‘I feel soft hearted, I feel cute, I have a feeling of disturbance or feeling of emotionless’. This disadvantaged the candidates as they could not score higher. Some would have the same feeling throughout their essay, like being sad. They lacked variety and they ended up focusing on general feelings like sad, pity, and happy. Moreover, they failed to exhaust the whole text. They would just abruptly stop anywhere, thus hindering them from scoring high.

Another weakness was the misunderstanding of the passage itself. Their feelings ended up not matching the quotes they picked from the passage because of flaws in understanding it. They did not understand that Khalima was a troublesome man, and they even blamed the wife for leaving him, stating that culturally she should withstand challenges in her marriage. They further went on to blame the wife throughout their essays while pitying Khalima for such an unfortunate situation in his life. Common errors were also seen in understanding the writer’s style, the use of language, the humour, and the implied meanings. Some candidates thought the house was empty because Khalima Zungu had been robbed. They went on to condemn the wife for not opening the door for her husband which put him in danger of being robbed. They also missed the fact that when Khalima “fell on the floor and remained there a hopeless heap”, it wasn’t that he was depressed or disheartened, but he just blacked out as he was too drunk to even be able to assess the situation. To some, it meant he had lost hope which was another misunderstanding. Even when he woke up, they misunderstood the words, “the scenery was not new to him”. To most candidates it meant it was not the first time that the wife had left Zungu, yet it meant that what Zungu saw was familiar as he had seen it before passing out on the floor.

Another common error was when candidates said Khalima Zungu became sick and was rushed to hospital because of stress. This was proof that candidates do not give themselves time to read carefully as it was clearly explained in the passage that he had inhaled the fumes from the burning house, thus the urge to vomit.

It also showed that candidates focus on what they are writing about is limited as Khalima Zungu would be given other different names such as Khalifa, Khalid, Khayelihle or Zuke and Zuma. Some would just refer to him as The Zungu or the man. Disadvantaged candidates were those with limited vocabulary and exposure, as they found themselves creating their own feelings. As the passage was too relatable, some candidates found themselves passing judgment and giving advice instead of answering the question.

Question 2

This question was not so popular with the candidates. It required candidates to say how the poet has made the poem so vivid and memorable. There were two extremes with the candidates who answered this question. There were those who did exceptionally well and those that performed dismally. Good answers were characterised by candidate's responses that showed understanding of the poet's use of imagery and how he depicts the night in a vivid and memorable way. They were able to analyse the imagery used by the poet. Such candidates were those who had an advantage of a much deeper English vocabulary, and analytical skills. They were able to first understand that the first-hand experience of nightfall by the poet was in itself memorable, and the use of imagery to convey the experience. The use of "sink" to describe the sunset and how the poet is filled with "awe and wonder" automatically made it vivid and memorable for the candidates. They analysed the transition from day to night and how indescribable it was to the poet. They were able to point out how each element in the universe, like the stars and moon played its own important role in a vivid and memorable way.

Weaker candidates found themselves unable to understand the poem as a whole together with the poet's language. They resorted to explaining what usually happens at night, totally ignoring what the poem is about. Most candidates would relate about their fear of nighttime, and how it becomes dangerous when it is dark, thus totally deviating from the beauty of the poem. The phrase, "the deepening of shades" made candidates to assume it meant the approach of danger, like it was lurking in the dark. Some candidates just paraphrased their responses without even explaining how then it is vivid and memorable in relation to what they had written. Most of the weaker responses were characterised by candidates being unable to express themselves clearly in English. Common errors noted were failure to decipher the meaning of the poem, instead changing it to suit their own understanding. Disadvantaged candidates were those who could not analyse the language of the poem as it was complicated for them. This in turn made them to be unable to answer the question properly. Also, the double barrel question was a bit of a challenge to the candidates as they could not bring out both clearly.

Recommendations

It is important that in preparing candidates for Literature in English Paper 2, teachers should try and:

- Expose candidates to the summary at the top. This helps candidates to know what the unseen text is about so they can never have a problem in misinterpreting it.
- Candidates must be exposed to answering unseen text, where they should know that in order to create coherence, they should start from the beginning of the text to the end. This helps create a flow in their work and not miss any important points.
- Candidates should be told that when answering the passage-based questions, they should stick to the dictates of the question instead of venturing beyond it to give advice or narrate their life experiences.
- Candidates should be trained to always approach a text with the aim of analysis than to just paraphrase it. Always the question is a guide of what is needed from candidates.
- Candidates should practise the unseen text and be made aware of the instructions that the bullet points are not the question but a guide.

